

# Market Analysis and Competitor Assessment: SaaS Membership Platforms for Volunteer-Run Outdoor and Activity Clubs

## Market Overview: The Landscape of Volunteer-Run Activity and Outdoor Clubs

The global market for volunteer-run recreational and outdoor activity clubs is defined by extreme operational fragmentation, severe administrative strain on volunteer leaders, and highly specialized functional demands that standard subscription, billing, or generalized e-commerce systems fail to satisfy.<sup>1</sup> This sector comprises hiking, mountaineering, skiing, cycling, and paddling clubs, which are primarily managed by non-technical, unpaid volunteers who cycle through administrative roles such as registrar, secretary, and treasurer.<sup>1</sup>

### Typical Club Sizes, Operational Budgets, and Dues

Recreational outdoor and sports clubs display a diverse range of membership sizes, ranging from small, informal local groups with fewer than 100 members to historic regional organizations.<sup>1</sup> The financial structures of these clubs are characterized by high price sensitivity, as annual membership dues are kept intentionally low to maintain community accessibility.<sup>5</sup>

| Organization Name                           | Primary Outdoor Focus                        | Active Membership Size             | Annual Membership Dues & Fees                                                             | Core Technology Stack & Tooling                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| British Columbia Mountaineering Club (BCMC) | Mountaineering, Climbing, Backcountry Skiing | 1,400+ active members <sup>6</sup> | Annual dues not specified; paid access to member cabins and booking software <sup>7</sup> | Proprietary database integrated with RezExpert reservation software <sup>7</sup> |

|                                               |                                         |                              |                                                                                                       |                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>North Shore Hikers (NSH)</b>               | Year-round Hiking, Snowshoeing          | Not specified                | \$30.00/year (Fixed calendar-year renewal ending November 30) <sup>5</sup>                            | Custom website database; PayPal; manual leader verification on Meetup <sup>5</sup> |
| <b>Trails Club of Oregon</b>                  | Hiking, Trail Maintenance, Lodge Access | Not specified                | \$50.00/year (plus \$15.00 entry fee); juniors are \$5.00/year <sup>9</sup>                           | Custom online forms; manual check payments; Eventbrite for trips <sup>1</sup>      |
| <b>Mountain West Outdoor Club (Boise, ID)</b> | Hiking, Rafting, Social Hikes           | Not specified                | \$20.00/year individual; \$40.00/year household bundle <sup>10</sup>                                  | Wild Apricot <sup>10</sup>                                                         |
| <b>Washington Alpine Club (WAC)</b>           | Mountaineering, Backcountry Travel      | Not specified                | \$40.00/year individual (\$20.00 seniors); Cabin access fees are \$150.00–\$250.00/year <sup>12</sup> | Custom digital forms; manual paper invoicing and bank checks <sup>12</sup>         |
| <b>Cleveland Hiking Club</b>                  | General Trail Hiking                    | 1,000+ members <sup>13</sup> | Not specified                                                                                         | Custom-built low-code database (Caspio platform) <sup>13</sup>                     |
| <b>Outdoor Adventure Club</b>                 | Guided Excursions, Backcountry Skiing   | Not specified                | \$199.00/first year (\$99.00/year subsequent renewals); monthly option                                | Custom website forms with automated recurring billing <sup>14</sup>                |

|  |  |  |                             |  |
|--|--|--|-----------------------------|--|
|  |  |  | \$20.00/month <sup>14</sup> |  |
|--|--|--|-----------------------------|--|

The financial constraints under which these clubs operate are remarkably tight.<sup>5</sup> For example, the North Shore Hikers allocate their \$30.00 annual membership fee across three highly rigid categories: \$14.00 is spent immediately on leader liability insurance, \$8.00 goes to the Federation of Mountain Clubs of BC to protect trail access, and only \$8.00 remains to cover the club's website, communication tools, and day-to-day operations.<sup>5</sup> This thin margin means a club with 300 members operates on an administrative budget of just \$2,400.00 per year, making standard association management platforms financially unviable.

### Current Tooling and willingness to Pay

Faced with limited budgets, volunteer boards often default to using basic consumer spreadsheets like Google Sheets or Microsoft Excel.<sup>1</sup> While spreadsheets are accessible and free, they lack payment integration, automated communication, and access control.<sup>1</sup> Once a club scales past 100 active members, managing this manual infrastructure leads to administrative bottlenecks.<sup>1</sup> Studies show that volunteer administrators in sports and recreation clubs spend between 8 and 15 hours per month on repetitive administrative tasks, while treasurers regularly spend 3 to 5 hours per week reconciling club finances.<sup>16</sup> Volunteer committees demonstrate a strong willingness to pay for specialized software when the administrative burden reaches a critical threshold where volunteers refuse to continue.<sup>16</sup> This willingness is further accelerated by regulatory and legal compliance pressures.<sup>16</sup> Across Europe and North America, strict data protection laws (e.g., GDPR) and child safeguarding mandates—such as the French background check law of March 8, 2024, or the German Führungszeugnis—require clubs to verify volunteer backgrounds and secure sensitive medical or personal data.<sup>16</sup> Storing this data in unencrypted spreadsheets shared via email exposes the club leadership to personal liability, making secure, automated databases a necessity rather than an optional luxury.<sup>16</sup>

### Competitor Matrix

To understand how Memba can position itself in this market, the following matrix compares the core features, pricing structures, and targets of thirteen primary competitors.

| Competitor                 | Primary Target Customer    | Entry Pricing Model             | Gaps for Volunteer Administrators | Suitability for Outdoor Clubs |
|----------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Wild Apricot <sup>18</sup> | Small-to-mid associations, | \$63.00/month (Flat rate for up | Complex interface,                | Moderate; feature-dense       |

|                                  |                                                                              |                                                                       |                                                                                                      |                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                  | nonprofits, local club chapters <sup>19</sup>                                | to 100 contacts) <sup>19</sup>                                        | stagnant development, contact-based billing traps, poor support <sup>22</sup>                        | but overly expensive and slow to use <sup>22</sup>                                         |
| <b>ClubExpress</b> <sup>25</sup> | Traditional hobby, athletic, and volunteer-led civic clubs <sup>25</sup>     | \$0.42/member/month (with a \$24.00/month minimum) <sup>26</sup>      | Dated 2000s UI, steep learning curve, heavy setup fees, undocumented API <sup>1</sup>                | High; has native trail maps and waiver guest passes, but hard to configure <sup>29</sup>   |
| <b>MemberPlane</b> <sup>20</sup> | Volunteer groups, local chapters, and PTAs <sup>22</sup>                     | Free plan (with a 4% platform fee) up to \$175.00/month <sup>20</sup> | Overly administrative feel, high transaction fees, limited Zapier integrations <sup>20</sup>         | Low; lacks outdoor-specific event tracking and map modules <sup>20</sup>                   |
| <b>Join It</b> <sup>31</sup>     | Local clubs, professional associations, and growing nonprofits <sup>32</sup> | \$29.00/month (Starter tier; up to 1,000 members) <sup>33</sup>       | No native website builder, core directory and messaging features gated in higher tiers <sup>32</sup> | Moderate; requires external event tools (Eventbrite) for trip management <sup>1</sup>      |
| <b>Memberful</b> <sup>35</sup>   | Independent creators, podcasters, newsletters, and publishers <sup>36</sup>  | \$49.00/month plus <b>4.9% transaction fee</b> <sup>35</sup>          | WordPress-centric, high entry fees, extremely basic community forum features <sup>36</sup>           | Low; completely missing member directories, waiver systems, and family plans <sup>37</sup> |
| <b>Raklet</b> <sup>31</sup>      | Professional associations,                                                   | Free CRM tier up to                                                   | Heavy setup required for                                                                             | Moderate; great interface                                                                  |

|                                                 |                                                                         |                                                                                  |                                                                                                 |                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                 | corporate clubs, and alumni networks <sup>22</sup>                      | \$99.00/month (Premium tier) <sup>39</sup>                                       | custom modules, generic directory filters <sup>15</sup>                                         | and mobile apps but lacks trip and carpool features <sup>39</sup>                  |
| <b>Mighty Networks</b> <sup>38</sup>            | Digital community builders, cohort courses, and creators <sup>38</sup>  | \$33.00/month (billed annually) with transaction fees on all tiers <sup>41</sup> | Host-led architecture, shallow analytics, lacks database CRM integrations <sup>41</sup>         | Low; no family units, offline check-in, or legal waiver coordination <sup>30</sup> |
| <b>WordPress Plugins (PMPPro)</b> <sup>37</sup> | Technical webmasters and sites with dedicated IT resources <sup>1</sup> | Free core plugin up to \$499.00/year (Standard tier) <sup>37</sup>               | Requires constant self-hosted updates, database conflicts, and security monitoring <sup>1</sup> | Low; high technical burden causes rapid volunteer burnout <sup>1</sup>             |
| <b>Google Groups</b> <sup>1</sup>               | Informal meetups and basic local email boards <sup>1</sup>              | Free <sup>1</sup>                                                                | Complete lack of databases, payments, renewals, directories, or waivers <sup>1</sup>            | Very Low; only useful as a supplementary mailing list <sup>1</sup>                 |
| <b>Mailchimp</b> <sup>1</sup>                   | Digital marketers and businesses focused on newsletters <sup>1</sup>    | Free up to 500 contacts, with steep pricing jumps beyond <sup>1</sup>            | No subscription billing engine or gated membership portals <sup>1</sup>                         | Low; acts as a data silo requiring constant manual CSV syncing <sup>1</sup>        |
| <b>Discourse</b> <sup>35</sup>                  | Online discussion networks and technical forums <sup>35</sup>           | Free self-hosted or custom cloud hosting plans                                   | No native dues billing, membership rosters, or registration forms <sup>43</sup>                 | Moderate; excellent for trip reports but lacks admin tools <sup>43</sup>           |

|                                |                                                                   |                                                                          |                                                                                           |                                                                                  |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Meetup</b> <sup>5</sup>     | General social organizers and event-discovery groups <sup>5</sup> | Organizer subscription fees plus transaction cuts                        | No capacity for family billing, custom profiles, or administrative databases <sup>5</sup> | Low; forces manual matching of RSVP lists to off-platform paid dues <sup>5</sup> |
| <b>Eventbrite</b> <sup>1</sup> | Commercial event hosts and workshop promoters <sup>1</sup>        | Free for free events; high transaction fees for paid events <sup>1</sup> | Lacks ongoing member profiles, subscription portals, and family plans <sup>1</sup>        | Low; highly expensive for recurring free or low-cost club outings <sup>1</sup>   |

## Individual Competitor Profiles

### 1. Wild Apricot

Wild Apricot targets small-to-medium associations, nonprofit chapters, and local recreational groups.<sup>19</sup> Its pricing structure is based on the total number of contacts in the system, starting at \$63.00/month for up to 100 contacts and rising to \$945/month for 50,000 contacts.<sup>19</sup> The platform offers a comprehensive feature set, including a member database, automated renewals, email campaigns, a website builder, and a mobile app.<sup>18</sup>

Its primary strengths lie in its deep membership automation, self-service portals, and advanced search filters.<sup>18</sup> However, user complaints frequently highlight severe product stagnation, an outdated website builder, and a decline in customer support quality since its acquisition by Personify.<sup>22</sup> A major operational weakness is its contact-based billing system, which charges clubs for lapsed members, prospects, and historical contacts, creating unexpected billing increases.<sup>22</sup>

Furthermore, the platform cannot process native refunds, forcing administrators to execute refunds manually inside Stripe or PayPal and then manually update the database record.<sup>22</sup> Usability is also hindered by granular administrative limits; for instance, giving a volunteer access to manage a single event exposes the entire database to security risks.<sup>44</sup>

### 2. ClubExpress

ClubExpress serves traditional volunteer-led clubs, sports leagues, and interest groups.<sup>25</sup> It uses an active per-member pricing model (\$0.42 per active member per month, with secondary members at \$0.20 per month and a \$24.00/month minimum)<sup>27</sup>, but charges high implementation setup fees ranging from \$150.00 to \$3,180.00.<sup>26</sup> Its core strengths include excellent phone support and highly specific add-on modules designed for outdoor groups.<sup>29</sup> These modules include snowmobile trail maps and trail status tracking (\$15.00/month), guest

passes with integrated digital liability waivers (\$40.00/month), group interest directories (\$20.00/month), and member boat fleet lists (\$12.00/month).<sup>29</sup>

The primary weaknesses of ClubExpress are its steep learning curve and its dated, 2000s-era user interface.<sup>1</sup> Non-technical administrators struggle to customize webpages or newsletters without extensive HTML programming knowledge.<sup>45</sup> Additionally, the public API is undocumented, file-upload tools are highly restrictive (such as rejecting PDFs in some modules), and mobile usability is clumsy for live trailhead RSVPs.<sup>3</sup>

### **3. MemberPlanet**

MemberPlanet is designed for local volunteer groups, PTAs, and community chapters.<sup>22</sup> It provides a free tier with high transaction fees (4%), scaling to paid plans up to \$175.00/month, and offers unlimited contacts across all plans.<sup>20</sup> Its features center on group SMS messaging, financial collections, survey tools, and mobile member cards.<sup>20</sup>

Its core strength is its flexible payment form customization and automated "Member Circles" for internal segmentation.<sup>20</sup>

However, its interface feels highly administrative, and it lacks tools for peer-to-peer community building.<sup>30</sup> Key weaknesses include high platform transaction fees, the lack of an integration ecosystem (such as Zapier), and limited options for non-technical users to customize branding or workflows.<sup>15</sup> For outdoor clubs, MemberPlanet is unsuitable due to its complete lack of trip planning, map modules, and structured liability waiver tracking.

### **4. Join It**

Join It targets local clubs, professional associations, and growing nonprofits seeking a modern membership solution.<sup>31</sup> Pricing starts at \$29.00/month (Starter plan with a 3% platform fee) and scales to \$99.00/month (Total plan with a 2% fee) and \$199.00/month (Extra plan with a 1.5% fee).<sup>33</sup> It offers a searchable database, Apple/Google Wallet membership cards, QR-code check-ins, and embeddable website registration widgets.<sup>32</sup>

Its core strength is its modern, highly stable integration-first architecture, which connects seamlessly with Mailchimp, Stripe, Slack, Eventbrite, and Zapier.<sup>32</sup>

The platform's primary weakness is its lack of a built-in website builder or content management system, forcing clubs to embed widgets into external sites.<sup>32</sup> Additionally, essential community features—such as member directories, offline payment options, and member-to-member messaging—are locked behind the \$99.00/month Total tier.<sup>33</sup> For outdoor clubs, Join It requires using external platforms like Eventbrite to handle trips and events, which introduces additional ticketing fees and database synchronization hurdles.<sup>1</sup>

### **5. Memberful**

Memberful, owned by Patreon, is built for content creators, publishers, and podcasters looking to monetize digital access.<sup>36</sup> It is priced at \$49.00/month plus a mandatory 4.9% transaction fee on all membership payments, in addition to standard Stripe fees.<sup>35</sup> Its features include custom

field collection, Apple/Google Pay, dynamic paywalls, and private podcast/newsletter delivery.<sup>35</sup> The platform's strengths are its highly polished, high-conversion checkout flow, excellent platform stability, and creator-retained data ownership.<sup>36</sup> However, Memberful is a poor fit for volunteer-run clubs.<sup>37</sup> Its percentage-based transaction fee acts as a tax on a club's local growth, and its support is frequently reported as slow and unresponsive.<sup>36</sup> It relies heavily on a WordPress-centric or external API architecture, offers basic community tools, and completely lacks physical check-in tools, family membership tracking, and legal waiver collection.<sup>36</sup>

## **6. Raklet**

Raklet is an all-in-one community management platform targeting professional associations, alumni networks, and corporate clubs.<sup>22</sup> It offers a free CRM tier and paid plans at \$49.00/month and \$99.00/month, scaling to enterprise tiers.<sup>39</sup> It features automated messaging (email and SMS), event ticketing, custom member profiles, and interactive community message boards.<sup>39</sup>

Its core strengths are its clean user interface, custom-branded iOS/Android mobile apps, and in-platform refund processing.<sup>28</sup>

Its weaknesses include a complex setup process for advanced modules, a lack of deep historical activity tracking, and limited formatting tools on the lower-tier page builders.<sup>15</sup> For outdoor clubs, Raklet lacks specific trip management features, and its premium mobile app features are too expensive for small, volunteer-run groups.<sup>28</sup>

## **7. Mighty Networks**

Mighty Networks focuses on online course communities, digital content creators, and professional cohort groups.<sup>38</sup> Pricing starts at \$33.00/month (billed annually) for the Community Plan and rises to \$99.00/month for the Business Plan, with transaction fees charged across all plans.<sup>41</sup> It features interactive feeds, live streaming, courses, private member messaging, and visual event calendars.<sup>38</sup>

Its strengths are its excellent peer-to-peer engagement, modern user interface, and AI-driven "Co-Host" community generation tools.<sup>38</sup>

However, the platform is structured around a "creator-to-follower" host model rather than a cooperative community structure.<sup>41</sup> It lacks deep bidirectional CRM integrations, and its analytics dashboards are too basic for operational forecasting.<sup>41</sup> For outdoor clubs, Mighty Networks has severe gaps: it cannot process family/household billing bundles, support offline check-ins, or manage digital legal waiver collections.<sup>30</sup>

## **8. WordPress Membership Plugins (e.g., Paid Memberships Pro)**

WordPress plugins like Paid Memberships Pro (PMPPro) target technical web developers and organizations with dedicated IT resources.<sup>1</sup> While the core plugin is free, professional tiers range from \$499.00 to \$999.00/year.<sup>37</sup> Features include tiered content restriction, customizable



checkouts, member directories, and multi-user fields.<sup>37</sup>

Its primary strength is its flat-rate pricing model and complete ownership over branding and code.<sup>37</sup>

However, the major weakness is the heavy maintenance overhead.<sup>1</sup> Volunteer-run clubs face severe risks with self-hosted plugins, as routine updates can cause database conflicts that break checkouts, corrupt member logs, or create security vulnerabilities.<sup>1</sup> This technical burden often leads to volunteer burnout.<sup>1</sup>

## 9. Point-Solution Gaps: Google Groups, Mailchimp, Discourse, Meetup, and Eventbrite

Recreational clubs often rely on a collection of free or cheap point-solutions to manage operations, though this approach introduces major coordination challenges.<sup>1</sup> **Google Groups** is used as a free mailing list but lacks a database, renewal logic, or billing tools.<sup>1</sup> **Mailchimp** provides attractive email newsletters but does not have a membership ledger, requiring volunteers to constantly export and import CSV files.<sup>1</sup> **Discourse** provides high-quality forum discussions and trip logs, but has no payment gateways to collect dues.<sup>43</sup> **Meetup** is popular for event discovery but cannot manage family memberships or private content, forcing leaders to manually cross-reference RSVPs with paper bank records.<sup>5</sup> **Eventbrite** handles event registration but does not support recurring dues or member profiles, and its high ticket fees quickly drain a club's limited budget.<sup>1</sup>

## Pain-Point Evidence and Operational Friction

The daily operation of volunteer-led clubs is characterized by administrative strain, financial leakage, and legal liabilities.<sup>16</sup>

### Volunteer Burnout and Spreadsheet Fragmentation

Volunteer leaders are rarely database administrators, yet legacy platforms force them to act as both.<sup>3</sup> When a club relies on spreadsheets, manual tasks can quickly become overwhelming: "The problem: most nonprofits manage their volunteers with spreadsheets, email chains, and prayer... Screening is inconsistent. Credentials don't transfer between orgs." — *Nonprofit Administrator*<sup>48</sup>

"The volunteers currently sign up on a Google Sheet... this collective roster is brought to an Excel sheet... after a month, all the sign ups are being calculated to create the attendance... it's quite tedious." — *Recreational Club Volunteer*<sup>49</sup>

These administrative tasks consume a significant amount of volunteer time:

"Volunteer burnout is the single biggest threat to grassroots sports clubs... It's the quiet resignation of the people who do the unglamorous work behind the scenes, the registrars, treasurers, secretaries... who keep everything running. And here's the thing: most of what burns them out is avoidable... manual, thankless admin tasks that eat up every spare hour." — *Sports Club Administration Report*<sup>17</sup>

"Chasing membership payments: This is the single biggest time drain... tracking who's paid, who hasn't... sending reminders... Clubs tell us this task alone can eat 5–8 hours per week during registration season." — *GAA Registrar Analysis* <sup>17</sup>

## **Usability Obstacles and Legacy Product Stagnation**

Clubs that try to migrate to legacy Association Management Software (AMS) like Wild Apricot or ClubExpress often find the interfaces dated and difficult to navigate.<sup>1</sup> This complexity creates friction for non-technical volunteers, who struggle with systems that require HTML coding or extensive technical knowledge <sup>45</sup>:

"It's failing. It's not a very easy to use system anymore... they were purchased by a company called Personify. They don't do any types of... upgrades... we're as an organization, we're outgrowing what they can provide." — *Association Director* <sup>22</sup>

"Right now, we have a website + email management tool that leaves so much to the imagination (ClubExpress...) it's not even funny. Our emails are not very attractive, and our website can be clunky..." — *Recreational Club Leader* <sup>46</sup>

This complexity is particularly challenging for older club members, who are often less tech-savvy:

"Considerable computer experience is necessary to manage the system and our volunteers don't all have the same level required. This puts the system at risk of unintended damage." — *Ski Club Director* <sup>44</sup>

## **Financial Leakage and Data Lock-In**

Clubs also face issues with data porting and financial leakage when using disconnected systems.<sup>2</sup> If a platform makes it difficult to export data, migrating to a new tool becomes a major hurdle:

"Someone (often a volunteer treasurer) is literally sending invoices one by one. It takes hours every month and mistakes are inevitable. Missed renewals—Members lapse because nobody reminded them. You lose 20% of your base annually just to administrative oversight." — *Join It Billing Report* <sup>2</sup>

"Some platforms make it deliberately difficult to export your member data. Forum discussions warn about formats that don't transfer cleanly or limited export options that trap you... One reviewer described a migration that cost significant staff hours and even embarrassment." — *AMS Migration Case Study* <sup>2</sup>

## **Legal Liabilities and signed Waiver Tracking**

For outdoor clubs, tracking liability waivers is a critical legal requirement.<sup>5</sup> Activities like mountaineering, skiing, and paddling carry inherent physical risks, making signed waivers essential for insurance coverage <sup>5</sup>:

"Every dollar of your membership is accounted for... \$14.00 Liability Insurance. Protects our volunteer leaders on every trip... Joining assumes acceptance of the club waiver, signed at the trailhead before each trip." — *North Shore Hikers Bylaws* <sup>5</sup>

"I, the undersigned, acknowledge that this Seniors for Nature Outdoor Club activity... involves risks... I hereby release the Seniors For Nature Outdoor Club... from all claims..." — *Canoe Club Waiver*<sup>50</sup>

Under current manual setups, tracking these waivers is highly inefficient. Leaders must manually collect paper waiver forms at the trailhead or cross-reference static PDFs sent via email, creating potential insurance gaps if a form is missed.<sup>5</sup>

## Pricing Benchmark and Revenue Model Mechanics

SaaS pricing in this market typically follows three structures: contact-based pricing, member-based billing, and transaction-fee-heavy models.<sup>22</sup>

### Pricing Models of Primary Competitors

- **Contact-Based Pricing (Wild Apricot, Raklet):** Bills clubs based on the total number of records in the database, including lapsed members, archived alumni, and prospects.<sup>22</sup>
- **Active Member-Based Pricing (ClubExpress):** Scales directly with the number of active members, but often requires significant upfront setup fees and paid add-on modules.<sup>26</sup>
- **Transaction Fee-Heavy Models (Memberful, Join It):** Charges a lower monthly subscription fee but takes a percentage-based transaction fee on all online payments.<sup>33</sup>

The following table compares the projected annual costs for a typical club across different pricing models as its active member base scales.

| Active Members<br>(Total Database with Alumni) | Wild Apricot<br>Annual Cost                                            | ClubExpress<br>Annual Cost                                                                    | Join It Annual<br>Cost                                                                 | Memberful<br>Annual Cost                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 150 Active Members (250 Total Contacts)        | \$1,764.00/year (Billed on 500-contact tier at \$147/mo) <sup>21</sup> | \$1,156.00/year (Basic setup fee of \$150 + \$0.42/member/month + \$24 minimum) <sup>26</sup> | \$483.00/year (\$29/mo Starter plan + 3% platform fee on \$4,500 volume) <sup>33</sup> | \$1,048.50/year (\$49/mo standard plan + 4.9% platform fee on \$4,500 volume) <sup>35</sup> |
| 500 Active Members (1,000 Total Contacts)      | \$3,024.00/year (Billed on 2,000-contact tier at                       | \$2,540.00/year (Basic setup fee + \$0.34/member/month + guest                                | \$1,488.00/year (\$99/mo Total plan + 2% platform fee on \$15,000                      | \$1,911.00/year (\$49/mo standard plan + 4.9% platform fee                                  |

|                                                       |                                                                                 |                                                                                          |                                                                                                   |                                                                                                     |
|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                       | \$252/mo) <sup>21</sup>                                                         | waiver module) <sup>26</sup>                                                             | volume) <sup>33</sup>                                                                             | on \$15,000 volume) <sup>35</sup>                                                                   |
| <b>1,500 Active Members</b><br>(3,000 Total Contacts) | <b>\$5,544.00/year</b> (Billed on 5,000-contact tier at \$462/mo) <sup>21</sup> | <b>\$5,700.00/year</b> (Usage-based billing + setup fee + premium support) <sup>26</sup> | <b>\$3,063.00/year</b> (\$199/mo Extra plan + 1.5% platform fee on \$45,000 volume) <sup>33</sup> | <b>\$3,381.00/year</b> (\$49/mo standard plan + 4.9% platform fee on \$45,000 volume) <sup>35</sup> |

## The True Cost of Ownership (TCO) Calculation

For platforms charging percentage-based transaction fees, the real cost of ownership escalates as a club grows.<sup>2</sup> The True Cost of Ownership ( $TCO$ ) can be calculated using the following equation:

$$TCO = (F_s \times 12) + [V_a \times (P_p + P_s)]$$

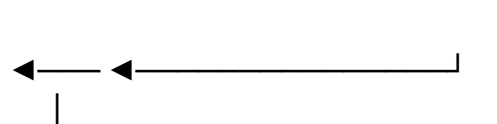
Where  $F_s$  represents the monthly SaaS base fee,  $V_a$  represents the annual transaction volume,  $P_p$  is the platform percentage fee, and  $P_s$  is the standard payment processor fee (e.g., Stripe's 2.9% + \$0.30 per transaction).<sup>33</sup> For a 500-member club with \$30.00 annual dues generating \$15,000.00 in total volume, Memberful's transaction-heavy model results in an annual platform cost of \$1,323.00 (base subscription of \$588.00 plus a platform fee of \$735.00), excluding standard payment gateway processing fees.<sup>35</sup>

## MVP Feature Recommendations for Memba

To address these pain points, Memba's Minimum Viable Product (MVP) should focus on automating core administrative tasks while maintaining an easy-to-use interface.<sup>15</sup>

Memba MVP System Architecture:

→ →



## 1. Dual-Engine Automated Renewal System

To prevent membership churn and eliminate manual billing, the core platform must support both calendar-fixed renewals (e.g., all memberships expire on November 30, regardless of join date) and rolling anniversary-based renewals.<sup>2</sup>

- *Mechanism:* Build an integration with Stripe Connect to support secure, automated payments via credit cards, Apple Pay, and Google Pay.<sup>18</sup> The renewal system should automatically trigger multi-stage notification emails (e.g., sent 30, 7, and 1 day prior to expiration) with direct checkout links to simplify the process.<sup>18</sup>

## 2. Linked Family and Household Memberships

Recreational clubs depend heavily on family participation. The database should allow primary members to link household records to a single billing account.<sup>10</sup>

- *Mechanism:* Provide a primary member with the ability to purchase a "Household Bundle" (e.g., up to two adults and unlimited dependents).<sup>10</sup> The primary member manages billing details and shared emergency contacts, while each linked family member receives an individual profile for event registration and waiver tracking.

## 3. Integrated Digital Waiver Ledger

To address the liability risks associated with outdoor clubs, waiver collection must be built directly into the member onboarding and guest signup flows.<sup>5</sup>

- *Mechanism:* Create an integrated digital signature tool.<sup>29</sup> During checkout, users must sign the club's specific liability waiver.<sup>5</sup> The system will then archive a timestamped, signed PDF linked directly to the member's profile, providing a clear audit trail for the club's insurance provider.<sup>5</sup>

## 4. Bidirectional Google Sheets Synchronization

To ease the transition for volunteers who are comfortable using spreadsheets, Memba should leverage this familiarity rather than forcing a complete process overhaul.<sup>1</sup>

- *Mechanism:* Develop a continuous, bidirectional integration with Google Sheets. Any profile updates made by a member (e.g., phone number or emergency contact changes) or billing updates (e.g., a lapsed subscription status) should instantly write to a synced Google Sheet.<sup>17</sup> This allows administrators to sort, view, and print rosters from a familiar spreadsheet interface, while the primary database remains secure.

## 5. Gated Directories and Private Content Portals

Outdoor clubs require private portals to host member directories, cabin reservation codes, and safety resources.<sup>5</sup>

- *Mechanism:* Provide a simple, embeddable registration widget that can be placed on any existing website (WordPress, Wix, Squarespace) via a single line of code.<sup>1</sup> Behind a

member login, offer a private dashboard with a searchable Member Directory (complete with privacy controls) and secure content areas for cabin booking links or safety guides.<sup>5</sup>

## 6. Granular Admin Permissions

Legacy platforms often use all-or-nothing admin structures, which can expose sensitive data.<sup>44</sup>

- *Mechanism:* Establish three predefined administrative roles:
  - *Owner/Treasurer:* Access to financial dashboards and bank settings.<sup>17</sup>
  - *Registrar:* Access to profile editing and CSV data exports.<sup>51</sup>
  - *Trip Leader:* Access to specific attendee lists, emergency contacts, and signed waiver logs for event check-ins, without exposing the full membership database.<sup>18</sup>

## Positioning and Go-To-Market Recommendations

### Strategic Positioning: The Independent, Human-First Platform

Memba should position itself as the independent, easy-to-use alternative to legacy platforms consolidated under private equity portfolios.<sup>22</sup> While competitor development has largely stagnated, and customer support has shifted to automated email systems, Memba should emphasize intuitive, modern design and responsive customer care.<sup>22</sup>

- *Key Messaging:* "Say goodbye to clunky, outdated database menus and unexpected fees for inactive contacts. Memba is built for trail builders, mountain climbers, and paddle clubs who need software that simply gets out of the way."<sup>22</sup>

### Fair, Non-Punitive SaaS Pricing Tiers

Unlike contact-based platforms that bill for inactive contacts, or transaction-heavy systems that tax growth, Memba should offer flat monthly tiers based strictly on the number of **active, paying members**.<sup>22</sup> This allows clubs to maintain unlimited archived contacts for historical records and insurance compliance without moving to more expensive pricing tiers.<sup>15</sup>

- *Active Tier 1 (Starter):* \$29.00/month (for up to 150 active members). Includes automated renewals, Google Sheets sync, Stripe checkout, and household bundles.
- *Active Tier 2 (Pro):* \$79.00/month (for up to 750 active members). Adds the digital waiver signature tool, searchable member directory, private content portal, and role-based permissions.
- *Active Tier 3 (Enterprise):* \$149.00/month (for up to 2,000 active members). Includes custom domain support and advanced trip communication tools.

### Go-To-Market Strategy: "Concierge Migration" to Eliminate Friction

The single greatest barrier preventing clubs from leaving legacy platforms is "migration dread"—the fear of losing historical data, disrupting recurring billing profiles, or corrupting member rosters.<sup>2</sup>

- *Execution:* Position concierge onboarding as a core differentiator. For clubs signing an annual contract, Memba's team will handle database cleanup, verify records, and migrate

all data onto the platform for free.<sup>2</sup> By absorbing this initial operational friction, Memba can easily displace legacy incumbents that have abandoned direct customer support.<sup>22</sup>

## Key Risks and Validation Experiments

### Risk 1: High Price Sensitivity and Low Software Budgets

- *Vulnerability:* Outdoor clubs with annual dues of \$20.00 to \$40.00 may resist paying a monthly SaaS fee, preferring to continue using manual spreadsheets because their operational reserves are extremely low.<sup>5</sup>
- *Validation Experiment: The Pre-Sales Board Proposal Campaign.*
  - *Setup:* Create a high-fidelity landing page detailing Memba's core features (such as automated renewals, family bundles, Google Sheets sync, and signed waiver storage).<sup>10</sup> Include an interactive "Generate Board Proposal" tool. This allows club registrars to enter their club's specific details and generate a pre-formatted, professional PDF business case to share with their executive board.
  - *Metric:* Track the conversion rate of landing page visitors who generate a board proposal PDF, and measure those who place a \$10.00 fully-refundable pre-order deposit to reserve a spot for concierge migration. Reaching 30 paid pre-orders from clubs with over 150 members validates a clear willingness to pay.<sup>1</sup>

### Risk 2: Resistance to Software Migration by Non-Technical Boards

- *Vulnerability:* Even if a club registrar wants to adopt Memba, older or less tech-savvy board members may block the migration due to a fear of learning a new system, disrupting Stripe billing, or losing historical spreadsheets.<sup>2</sup>
- *Validation Experiment: The Standalone "Waiver & Sheet" Pilot.*
  - *Setup:* Package Memba's Google Sheets sync and digital waiver collection tool as a standalone, zero-risk integration.<sup>29</sup> Offer it to target clubs on a free 30-day trial. The club can keep using their existing website, PayPal buttons, and spreadsheets, but they use Memba solely to collect online waiver signatures, which instantly write to their active Google Sheet.<sup>5</sup>
  - *Metric:* Monitor adoption and board engagement. If at least 15 clubs successfully set up the waiver-sheet integration and collect signatures within 30 days, it proves that the non-technical board can comfortably adopt Memba's ecosystem without experiencing software friction.<sup>3</sup>

### Risk 3: Feature Creep via Legacy Activity and Trip Modules

- *Vulnerability:* Outdoor clubs may eventually demand complex, highly specialized modules—such as avalanche course scheduling, physical gear locker reservations, sailboat fleet tracking, or trail status mapping.<sup>7</sup> Attempting to build all of these features into the MVP will exhaust development resources and bloat the platform.
- *Validation Experiment: The Integrations-First Feature Gate.*

- *Setup:* Build simple, robust integration fields rather than custom modules. For event tracking, sync natively with Eventbrite; for trail conditions, link directly to Trailforks.<sup>1</sup> Add "Feature Requests" buttons inside the initial admin console for "Native Trip Planning," "Gear Reservation," and "Cabin Booking."
- *Metric:* Track click-through rates and quantitative feedback. If over 50% of active admins consistently trigger the "Native Trip Planning" request button over a 90-day period, it justifies allocating engineering capital to build that specific, high-intent module natively. Otherwise, keep the system lean and maintain external integrations.<sup>1</sup>

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